Resolving Conflict with Your Boss

Prepare in Advance for Meeting with Your Boss

Once you decide to have a meeting with your boss, the first thing you should do is prepare yourself psychologically. This means that you should get clear about your concerns and how to approach them.

- Write down a short description of the situation that you would like to bring up.

- What specific behavior or circumstance bothered or affected you?

- How did you feel and why?

- May it be that there is a deeper or unresolved problem that made this situation feel worse?

- Has this happen in the past or is it something new? If it's a pattern, how often does it happen?

Write down key phrases using the conflict resolution skills taught in this course, such as the XYZ statements found in the Effective Communication Techniques video.

When (be specific) you did this (what they did) I had this reaction…

Practice: If you're feeling nervous or uncomfortable, the best thing you can do is practice what you want to say. By practicing, you will be more confident and sound more natural in your approach. You can practice with a friend or family member as well, so that they can give you feedback. You should also practice your body language, maintaining your composure, and managing your emotions.

Prepare an agenda: The best thing you can do is prepare an agenda of what you want to discuss in your meeting. Keep in mind your boss may have many things going on and having an agenda will help keep the conversation focused and brief. Also, make sure you bring anything that will be needed or the meeting, such as a report, something that needs to be signed, or other supportive material. So, what do you want to address and in what order?

Define desired outcomes and possible solutions in advance:

Just like we discuss elsewhere in the course, always have clearly defined outcomes going into the conversation, meaning you need to know what you hope to get out of it. What results are you wanting to accomplish by addressing this situation?

You also may want to have possible solutions that you can suggest, which will show your manager that you have thought this through and that you are being solution-oriented. This also gives you the opportunity to clearly express what you want. Are there any solutions you want to suggest?

Discuss the Problem

When it comes time to discuss the problem with your boss, remember to avoid impulsive reactions that you may regret later. In many cases, you will want to give yourself time to process a situation before addressing it, especially if the situation just happened and you have reacted emotionally. When you approach or meet with your manager, make sure that you are in the right state of mind first. Then, follow these tips to keep the conversation going smoothly (as well as the other strategies taught in this course).

- State facts and avoid talking about your emotions unless you are explicitly addressing something that was hurtful
- Do not accuse or blame
- Don’t assume the supervisor knows the nuances of your job
- Focus on problem-solving
- Ask for insights and advice
- Don’t interrupt
- Listen to their view point to gain insights and determine mutually beneficial solutions

Follow Through After the Meeting

Make sure that you follow through on your end of the deal. It is important that you keep your commitments, and if for some reason you cannot, address it with your boss as soon as possible so that you can build trust moving forward.

You may also want to confirm your agreements in writing. After the meeting, you can send an email to your manager summarizing what you agreed upon to make sure that you are on the same page. It also gives you an opportunity to thank them for their time and for addressing the situation. This will also give you something in writing to show them if they do not hold up their end of the bargain.